



The Experiment

A Personal Truth

Don't just take it from us. Listen to what others have to say about XP. Sure, it might be easy for experienced users to jive well with it, but how does XP figure in the hands of a newcomer?

To test this question, we put a computer system in front of a person who isn't the geeky, system administrator type. We sat with our trusty test subject, who calls himself 'Soggy', and made him install, use and abuse Windows Me, Windows XP, and then compare the two.

At the end of it all, this turned out to be a fresh, new experience. Everyone survived and there were no frayed nerves. Even the system was fine. Here's the experience:

Installing

Getting Windows Me running wasn't so hard. I was just asked a few questions before the program took over. I used to wonder anyways what that millennium moniker was all about. Now I know, but this XP is much better—you know, the entire

process seems simplified. And it looks so cool too!

Setting up

Honestly, I really didn't notice the time. I just did the set up! However, this XP, surprisingly, took more time overall to install. Why does the process take longer in

XP? It seems to me as if there are many more files here to install. XP sure is thick!

TIME TAKEN: Installing and setting up — 47 minutes for Me and 62 minutes for XP

Configuring

Talk about being totally confused! Just as I was getting used to setting up things in Me, XP comes and bewilders me with its simplicity. I am not used to software so simple. I mean, what's wrong with Microsoft?! Just look at the Control Panel! It has REALLY changed and I think I will stick to the old



Sougat 'sOgster' Garai

look till I get somewhat adjusted to this XP. The change in location and layout of icons really threw me off.

There's one thing though: adding hardware such as mouse and external drives is much easier in XP. Me sucks in this regard.

TIME TAKEN: Configuring — 8 minutes for Me and 7 minutes for XP

Using

I've been hearing a bit too much about how XP makes things easy, how XP is faster and all that jazz. While I really feel that both XP and Me are pretty much the same as far as using them goes, XP seems to be a lot more organised in its layout and presentation. The Help is better than in Me, and basically, XP seems to walk you through the computer better than Me. Frankly, apart from this, I really don't see any other 'methods' that XP has applied to make your task simpler. It just seems better marketing and design to me!

centrally accessed with the Help and Support centre. The standard Windows Update is responsible for updating all drivers and patches as soon as they are out.

Windows Update is ingrained into the Help and Support centre which features an assortment of practical features such as pointing to the Hardware and

to. Since it only keeps a check on the system files, you needn't worry about losing personal data when bringing a damaged installation back to life.

In XP Professional, the Device Driver Rollback function maintains a copy of an older driver when installing the new one. The old driver can be recalled if the installed driver gives problems.

have the option to install the language settings during installation itself, or after installation.

Indian language fonts in Windows XP are based on the TrueType format which means that you can easily download and install these scripts on your computer, and while you type, a keyboard layout on-screen helps identify the characters.

The great thing is there are no booting blues. It's a bliss for small customers who operate on hardware provided by assemblers

Tripti Awade, CEO, Alnisha Software

Software Compatibility page. Using this, one can quickly research the hardware that has been given XP approval. If local help will not suffice, the Help and Support centre blends seamlessly with Microsoft's Knowledge Base where users can access a vast pool of support online.

System Restore is an excellent tool to recover an XP environment if something goes wrong with its system files. This function automatically takes snapshots of a computer's state which you can revert back



The pre-release to XP contained Smart Tags which, due to consumer protest and cries from the competition, was taken out.

Linguistic XP?

XP has you covered in India. It now speaks nine different regional Indian languages while Windows 2000 supported just Hindi and Tamil initially. Hindi, Marathi, Gujarati, Tamil, Telugu, Sanskrit, Konkani, Kannada and Punjabi can now be called mother tongues in XP. None of the previous home versions of the Windows operating system offered local language support. Users can now access all the nine languages using Microsoft's Office XP suite. You

Product activation

This has been the hottest topic amongst technology conversationalists. Microsoft's latest attempt to curb the reach of the long, sinewy fingers of pirates comes in the shape of Product Activation. When a user purchases a copy of Windows XP, Home or Professional edition, a 30-day time day limit is set to 'activate' the OS. If within that time XP isn't activated, it ceases all function until and unless activation is done.

Activation involves connecting to the Internet after which your configuration details are scanned by XP and sent to a Microsoft server. The reason Microsoft stores information about what's inside your PC is that if a copy of XP is installed on another computer, details about that